

JKBOSE

🔥 2026 CLASS 11th 🔥

Prose

ENGLISH

LECTURE-2

BY-HUSSAIN SIR



TOPICS TO BE COVERED

1 ... Detailed explanation of the Chapter

2 ... MCqs (as poll)

3 ...

4 ...

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

"The Portrait of a Lady" is taken from Khushwant Singh's collection of autobiographical essays titled **The Portrait of a Lady: Collected Stories** (published in various editions). It's often included in anthologies of his short stories and essays.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

Introduction

The story is a touching account of the writer's relationship with his grandmother. It highlights the bond of love, respect, and affection between the author and his grandmother, and shows how life, relationships, and traditions change with time. The narrative is written in first person, giving it a personal and emotional touch.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khushwant Singh*

Chapter Summary

In 'The Portrait of a Lady', *Khushwant Singh* has given an account of his grandmother. He draws a life-like portrait. She was very old. Her face was wrinkled. Her hair was white. It was hard to believe that once she had been young and pretty. His grandfather's picture hung above the mantelpiece in the drawing room. He wore a big turban. His clothes were loose. He looked at least a hundred years old. It was hard to believe that he had once a wife or children.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

Khushwant Singh's grandmother was a short lady. She was fat and slightly bent. She couldn't walk straight. She hobbled about the house. She had to keep one hand on her waist. It was to balance her stoop. In the other she held a rosary. She was always telling the beads. Her lips constantly moved in prayer. She put on white clothes. Her ^{Hair} silver locks scattered over her pale face. She looked like snowy mountains in winter. She was a picture of peace and contentment. She was very old. Perhaps she could not have looked older. She looked the same for the last twenty years.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

Khushwant Singh and his grandmother were good friends. His parents went to the city. They left him with her in the village. She took good care of him. She used to wake him up in the morning. She got him ready for school. She said her morning prayer in a sing-song manner. She hoped that he would learn it by heart. He liked her voice but never bothered to learn it. Then she would fetch his wooden slate. She had already washed it and plastered it with yellow chalk. She would take an earthen inkpot and a red-pen. She would tie them in a bundle and hand it to him. She would give him a thick stale chapatti with little butter and sugar spread on it. It was his breakfast. She carried several stale chapattis with her for the village dogs.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

His grandmother always went to school with him. The school was attached to the temple. The priest taught children the alphabet and the morning prayer. The children sat in two rows in the verandah. They would sing the alphabet or the prayer in a chorus. The grandmother sat inside the temple. She would read holy books. Then they would walk home together. The village dogs would gather at the temple door. They threw chapattis to them. The dogs would growl and fight with each other. The narrator's parents sent for them in the city. It was a turning point in their friendship. They shared the same room. But the grandmother no longer went to school with him. The narrator used to go to an English school in a motor bus. There were no dogs in the streets. So the grandmother took to feeding the sparrows.

QUESTION

What was always tied in the corner of the grandmother's sari?

A

A rosary ✓

B

A handkerchief ✗

C

A coin ✗

D

A key ✗



QUESTION

Who is the author of "The Portrait of a Lady"?

- A R.K. Narayan
- B Khushwant Singh
- C Marga Minco
- D Anita Desai



QUESTION

How did the grandmother help the author in the village?

A By teaching him English ✗

B By teaching him music ✗

C By teaching him cycling ✗

D By teaching him scriptures ✓



QUESTION

What did the grandmother feed everyday in the village?

- A Dogs
- B Cows
- C Crows
- D Sparrows



The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

Years rolled by. They saw less of each other. Sometimes she would ask him what the teacher had taught him. She did not believe in the things they taught at the English school. She was unhappy. She did not like English or Science. She felt sad that there was no teaching about God and the scriptures at school. The narrator one day told her that they were being given music lessons. She was disturbed. She thought music quite indecent. For her, it was good only for prostitutes and beggars. It was not meant for gentle folk.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

The narrator went to university. He was given a room of his own. The common link of friendship was broken. The grandmother accepted her loneliness quietly. She was always busy with her spinning wheel and reciting prayers. She rarely talked to anyone. In the afternoon, she relaxed for a while. Then she would feed the sparrows. She sat in the verandah. She broke the bread into little bits. Then she would throw them to sparrows. Hundreds of sparrows came there. They created a hell of noise. Some came and sat on her legs. Others would sit on her shoulders. Some would sit even on her head. She smiled but never frightened them away. Feeding the sparrows was the happiest half-hour of the day for her.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

The narrator decided to go abroad for higher studies. He was to remain away for five years. The grandmother was very old. She could die any moment. The narrator was worried. But the grandmother was not upset. She showed no emotion. She came to the railway station to see him off. Her lips moved in prayer. Her mind was lost in prayer. Her fingers were busy telling the beads of her rosary. She kissed his forehead silently. The narrator thought that it was the last sign of physical contact between them.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

The narrator returned home after five years. His grandmother met him at the station. She did not look a day older. She did not speak anything. She held him in her arms. She went on reciting her prayers. In the afternoon she fed the sparrows as usual. In the evening a change came over her. She didn't pray. She collected the women of the neighborhood. She got an old drum. She continued thumping the old drum for several hours. She started singing. She sang of the homecoming of warriors. They had to persuade her to stop. She might overstrain herself. It was for the first time that she had forgotten to pray.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

The next morning she fell ill. She had a mild fever. She told them that her end was near. She realised that she had forgotten to pray. She didn't want to talk. It would be a waste of time. She ignored their requests. She lay peacefully in bed. She was praying and telling beads. Then her lips stopped moving. The rosary fell down from her lifeless fingers. Her face looked pale but peaceful. She was dead. She was laid on the ground. She was covered with a red shawl. Arrangements for her funeral were being made.

The Portrait of a Lady *Khuswant Singh*

It was evening. The sun was setting. They brought a wooden stretcher. They stopped halfway in the courtyard. Thousands of sparrows sat near her dead body. They did not chirrup. Everyone felt sorry for the birds. The narrator's mother brought some bread. She broke it into little crumbs. She threw these crumbs to the sparrows. The birds took no notice of them. Then they carried her dead body outside. The sparrows flew away quietly. The crumbs of bread still remained lying there in the courtyard. Evidently, the sparrows had come to mourn the death of the grandmother.

QUESTION

What disturbed grandmother when they shifted to the city?

- A Busy roads
- B. New house
- C English school ✓
- D Lack of temples



QUESTION

What subject did the grandmother dislike the most?

A Maths ✗

B Science ✗

C English ✗

D Music ✓



QUESTION

What did the grandmother do in her spare time in the city?

- A Slept ✗
- B ^{Spinning}
Knitted and prayed ✓
- C Watched TV ✗
- D Talked to neighbours ✗



QUESTION

What did the grandmother stop doing the day before she died?

A

Eating



B

Talking



C

Walking



D

Praying



QUESTION

The story mainly depicts—

- A Modern life ✓
- B Friendship ✓
- C Bond between grandson & grandmother ✓
- D Fantasy ✓



QUESTION

The grandmother is a symbol of—

A Faith and tradition ✓

B Modernity ✗

C Rebellion ✗

D Luxury ✗



QUESTION

The three phases of the author's relationship with his grandmother before he left the country to study abroad.

Answer:

The three phases of the author's relationship with his grandmother before he left the country to study abroad are as follows:

In Village House– when they lived in the village house, his grandmother helped him to get ready and come to school with him.

In the City – when they shifted to the city, the author started going to school on a bus. Although He shared a room with his grandmother, she could not help him in his studies. The grandmother started praying and feeding sparrows in her free time.

University life – when the author started going to the university he was given a separate room. The common link of friendship was snapped. The grandmother spent most of the time in spinning, praying, and feeding the sparrows.

QUESTION

Three reasons why the author's grandmother was disturbed when he started going to the city school.

Answer:

The three reasons why the author's grandmother was disturbed when he started going to the city school are as follows:

No religious teaching- There was no teaching about god and the scriptures in that school of the city. She was unable to help in the author's studies- when they levied in the village grandmother helped him in his studies, but here in the city school she was unable to help him. Teachings of Music- When grandmother came to know that music was taught in the school she got disturbed. She believed that music is made for beggars and harlots.

QUESTION

Three ways in which the author's grandmother spent her days after he grew up.

Answer:

The three ways in which the author's grandmother spent her days after he grew up are:

Spinning: When the author was given his separate room she started spinning. She had been doing her spinning work all day.

Praying: Her lips always moved in the inaudible prayer of god and her hands were busy in telling beads of rosary.

Feeding the Sparrow: In the village, she used to feed stale chapati to the street dogs, but in the city house she started feeding sparrows in the afternoon, she fed them with frivolous rebukes.

QUESTION

The odd ways in which the author's grandmother behaved just before she died.

Answer:

Just before her death, the author's grandmother behaved in odd ways, In the evening she did not pray, gathered the women of the neighbourhood, and started beating a broken drum and singing about the return of the warrior to home, the next day she fell ill, she said that her end is near now, she refused to talk to us and she ignored our protests. She was peacefully lying on the bed praying and chanting the rosary.

QUESTION

The way in which the sparrows expressed their Sorrow when the author's grandmother died.

Answer:

The dead body of the grandmother was lying wrapped in a red shroud and the sparrows gathered around the grandmother's corpse. They stopped Chirping as if they were paying a silent tribute to her.

The sparrows took no notice of the breadcrumbs which were offered to them by the Author's mother. When grandmother's dead body had been taken off they flew away quietly.

QUESTION

The author's grandmother was a religious Person. What are the different ways in which We come to know this?

Answer:

While reading the chapter, we can undoubtedly say that the author's grandmother was a religious person. Her Fingers were always busy telling the beads of the rosary, and her lips continuously moved in inaudible Prayer.

When she lived in Village, she went to the temple daily and carried stale Chapatis for street dogs. She also read the Scriptures. And when they shifted to the city house, His grandmother started feeding sparrows. At the end of her life, she did not waste her last moments talking to anyone. She died praying and telling her beads.

QUESTION

Describe the changing relationship between the author and his grandmother. Did their feelings for each other change?

Answer:

The author's Parents left him with his grandmother in the village house. They lived together all the time and became the best friends. She used to wake him up in the morning and get him ready for school. After some time when the author's parents were comfortably settled in the city, they sent for them. That was the turning point in their relationship. Now She did not go to school with her grandson She also did not like the study that was taught in the city school. When the author Started going to university for higher study, he was given a separate room. In Conclusion. The change in the relationship came only because of the Changing circumstances, But their feelings for each other never changed.

QUESTION

Would you agree that the author's grandmother was a person strong in Character?
If yes, give instances that show this.

Answer:

Yes, the author's grandmother was a person of strong character, She strongly believed in God and used to read scriptures. But when She come to know that things were not going her way. She accepted the situation without any questions.

She came to know like an actual religious soul that her end was near and she accepted her death as quietly as she had been accepting other changes taking place about her.

QUESTION

Have you known Someone like the author's grandmother? Do you feel the same sense of loss with regard to someone whom you loved and lost?

Answer:

Yes, While reading this story I remind of my own grandmother. She was also very old and wrinkled as the author's grandmother. I spent a lot of happy time with my grandmother. She was very possessive and protective of me. She used to tell me a bedtime story. She did all my work like serving food for me and getting me ready for school. She believed in hard work and taught us the lesson of hard work too. When I was 30 years old, she, after a brief illness, joined the majority. we still miss her a lot, our childhoods would have been colourless and tasteless if she had not been there.

Thank
You